ZENTRAL HACK 2026 · AGENT HARNESS

Spec in.
Strategy out.



An agent harness for games it has never seen.

Elias · Isaak · Timo

THE TASK · THE INSIGHT

An unseen game, a fixed budget, only wins count

The task

A $0.03 · 3 min

B $0.50 · 10 min

C $10 · 30 min

What research says

9 / 10

games where LLM-written code + search matches or beats a top LLM playing directly

Code World Models, Google DeepMind

Our insight

The LLM is the programmer, not the player.

Sources: Zentral Hack 2026 task description; Code World Models for General Game Playing, arXiv 2510.04542.

THE HARNESS

Many drafts, one verified simulator, one champion

spec.md in

1
Write
drafts + a simulator

2
Verify
against the spec

3
Self-play
real tournament rules

4
Improve
challengers vs. champion

5
Guard
never a forfeit

strategy.py out

↻ repeat while time and money last

HOW WE BUILT IT

Built like it works: measure, decide, repeat

10

games, 4 never tuned on

120+

measured runs

≈ $45

API cost

Built with Claude Code · 416 automated tests

EPOCH 1

Ablation

kept only what wins

EPOCH 2

Tournament conditions

selection = reality

EPOCH 3

Midpoint feedback

weak runs traced and fixed

THE ORGANISERS' MIDPOINT EVALUATION

Our best strategy topped the hidden game

#1 of 20

strategies on the hidden game (94.8% won)

2nd of 4

teams overall, task B

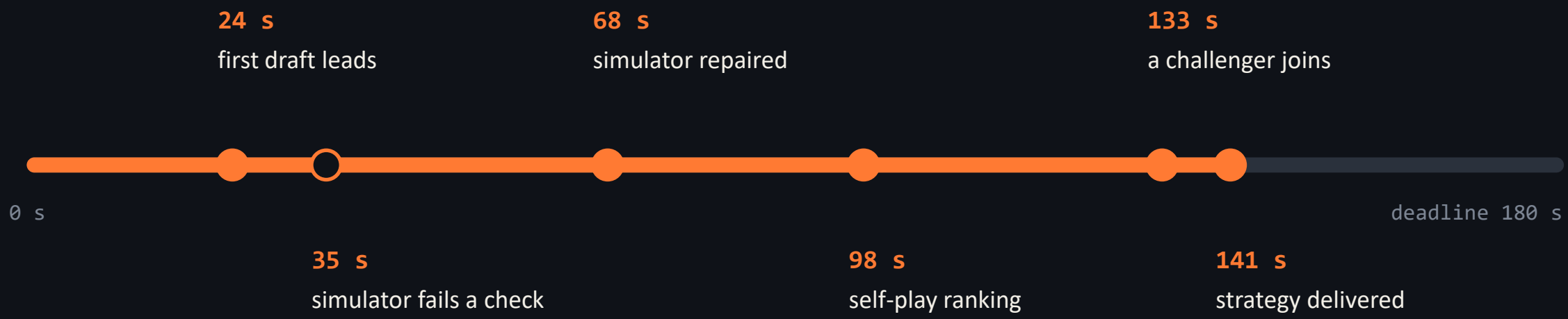
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forfeits in 112 delivered strategies

Weak runs traced to our simulator check and fixed. On fresh, untuned games the final harness beats the one-shot baseline 36–0–12 and 48–0–0.

DEMO · ONE REAL RUN, FROM SPEC TO STRATEGY.PY

141 seconds, 1.8 cents, one champion



Spec in. Strategy out. Never a forfeit.